

Zen and the art of tech travel

As I sit in here in Central Park, with the awe inspiring New York City skyline forming the perfect backdrop for inspiration, I can't help but base my editorial on travel. I'm here on "official business" of course, but much to the team's envy and ire, there can only be so much business you can do when you're visiting a city like NYC!

Anyway, you might wonder what travel has to do with technology. A hell of a lot!

Foreign trips aren't uncommon for us at Digit, but this one was very different compared to say one of my first trips abroad – Taipei, Computex 2011 I believe. What was different about this most recent one? The pivotal role technology played through the entire sojourn.

If you think about it, 2011 isn't that long ago but I can't help but feel it was in a different era.

For this trip, right from mapping, planning my stay, identifying points of interest, and many of the other nitigrities, I couldn't have done it without my phone and the hundreds of services that have made travel a much easier proposition. Sure many of these services existed back then, most existed for certain when I went to SF last year and yet this time around, everything just worked seamlessly. The availability of these services on the all important screen – your smart-phone – combined with improved battery life or rather more accurately, the availability of cheap and compact high capacity powerbanks, has taken everything from a lofty proof of concept level right down to everyday reality.

Travel Tech, if I could call it that, has matured. And just in the past year at that.

On this trip, Google Now was my tour guide, my friendly local contact, and my secretary. Right from reminding me when to leave from home to catch my flight to regular "things to do" cards featuring nearby attractions, to giving me my entire itinerary (big yay! to machine read mails), conversion rates, daily/hourly forecasts, and even news from back home (my heart goes out to our readers from in and around Nepal) – Google Now took care of everything.

In addition to whatever on-the-spot recommendations I was getting from Google Now, I also installed and tried out a couple of Guided Tour apps for the times when I wanted to go out on planned outings. For culinary expeditions there was Zagat, Yelp and even Foursquare, which gave some pretty nifty mood-based recommendations for not just food but shopping too.

Google Maps was another life saver. Apart from regular navigation, Google Maps allowed me to receive custom maps from friends who have lived in Manhattan. On one particular occasion I was able to easily find a little bakery in the Grand Central station's concourse using Google's Internal Map schematics. The bakery was marked out on a shared map for it's Banana Pudding, which by the way, was totally worth every overpriced cent.

It almost makes me wonder how people managed to get by without this Travel Tech all around. Maybe they had to actually talk to people to get around? The horror! *Gasp* No I'm kidding obviously, and yet there's an app for that too! Socialising, making friends on your trips, even specialised hookup apps for travelers. Ahem, not that I tried Tripr or Wingman. iSwear! (they're on iOS).

These travel apps and services – although impressive – are barely scratching the surface though. Perhaps in the future there will be this one app to rule all travel (Google Now comes close but it's not quite there yet). Imagine an all powerful app that integrates all of the above data points and based on your location and a bit of AI, tells you things like "hey it appears you're heading downtown on the 3 train towards East Village, why not switch to the Q train, step out into the Flatiron district and start a guided tour? Once you're done you can pick up a slice of Pizza from Artichoke which Mihir marked on the map he shared with you". Creepy? Maybe. Useful? For sure. Now imagine what else could be done with the Internet of Things kicking into full swing.

So that was my brief ode to how technology has yet again completely, and going forward, irrevocably infused itself into an important facet of everyday life – travel. I'm really excited and looking forward to seeing which other facets tech will conquer next. And I mean not just at the prototype level, or something only the privileged 0.1 percent of the world can afford or experience; no I'm talking about completely transforming the way we – the ordinary folk – do things. Healthcare? Home automation? What do you think? 



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